INDIA: POPULATION, COMMUNITIES AND TRIBAL GEOGRAPHY

Updated comprehensive notes for UPSC / State Civil Services

With separate Andhra Pradesh and Telangana profiles

India population census baseline as on 3 November 2026. Census 2027 is notified and in progress/planning; its population results are not yet available. AP and Telangana figures below use the 2011 census geography adjusted to the post-2014 state boundaries where applicable.HOW TO USE THESE NOTES: DATA DISCIPLINE FIRST

Critical update . These data are based as on 3 November 2026, Census 2027 has been notified, but fresh population results have not been released.

- Census count = an official enumeration at a specified reference time. A projection, sample survey, administrative register or state socio-economic survey is not a census count.
- For AP and Telangana, the 2011 census was conducted before the bifurcation of Andhra Pradesh. State totals in later government profiles are mapped to the post-bifurcation boundaries; transferred Khammam mandals and subsequent district reorganisations must be kept in mind.
- District names and counts have changed substantially since 2011. A current district cannot automatically be compared with a 2011 census district without reconstructing the relevant boundary.
- Religion is enumerated in Census tables. The 2011 Census published SC and ST population totals and notified community tables. It did not publish a comprehensive caste-wise population count for all castes/OBCs.
- Use 'Scheduled Tribe' (ST) or 'Adivasi/tribal communities' in context. Tribal communities are not culturally, linguistically or economically homogeneous.

1. CENSUS OF INDIA: MEANING, HISTORY AND CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS

A population census is the complete enumeration of all persons in a country or defined territory at a specified reference time. It records demographic, social and economic characteristics and provides small-area data for planning and administration.

Aspect	Updated position
Legal basis	Census Act, 1948 and Census Rules, 1990, as amended.
Constitutional position	Census is a Union subject: Entry 69, Union

	List, Seventh Schedule; Parliament legislates under Article 246.
First census exercise	1872: a non-synchronous/experimental all-India census exercise.
First synchronous census	1881: first regular, synchronous all-India census; decennial censuses followed.
Last completed census	2011, the 15th Census in the series and 7th after Independence.
Next census	Census of India 2027: officially notified; the 16th in the series and 8th after Independence.
Reference date	Generally 00:00 hours of 1 March 2027; special 1 October 2026 reference date for specified snow-bound areas.
Census authority	Office of the Registrar General and Census Commissioner, India, Ministry of Home Affairs.

Constitutional trap Entry 69 is in the Union List (not State List or Concurrent List). Article 246 distributes legislative competence; the operational statute is the Census Act, 1948.

Census 2027: what is new and what to remember

- Two phases: Phase I—Houselisting and Housing Census (housing condition, amenities and household assets); Phase II—Population Enumeration (individual demographic, socio-economic, educational, migration and fertility details).
- The exercise introduces digital data collection and an optional self-enumeration facility, followed by enumerator verification/house-to-house operations.
- The Union Government announced that caste enumeration will be included in the population enumeration phase. This is distinct from the already published 2011 religion tables and SC/ST tables.
- The general reference moment is 00:00 hours on 1 March 2027. Some snow-bound areas have a different reference date. Specific state schedules have been notified separately and revised for certain states.
- As on 3 November 2026, do not quote Census 2027 population totals, caste totals or final demographic indicators: enumeration/results are not yet complete/published.

Official references: Census of India portal; PIB releases dated 4 June 2025 and 30 March 2026; ORGI Gazette notifications listed on the Census portal. See Sources at the end.

2. INDIA: CENSUS 2011 AT A GLANCE

Indicator	Census 2011 figure	Interpretation / exam note
Total population	1,210,854,977 (about 121.09 crore)	Second-largest national population at the time.
Male population	623,270,258	About 51.5% of total.
Female population	587,584,719	About 48.5% of total.
Decadal growth (2001–11)	17.64% (commonly rounded to 17.7%)	Lower than 21.54% in 1991–2001.
Population density	382 persons/km²	Up from 325 in 2001.
Overall sex ratio	943 females per 1,000 males	Up from 933 in 2001.
Child sex ratio (0–6)	918 girls per 1,000 boys	Down from 927 in 2001; major concern.
Urban population	31.16% (about 37.7 crore)	Rural share about 68.84%.
Rural population	68.84% (about 83.3 crore)	Still the majority in 2011.
Literacy rate	74.04%	Census literacy definition applies to age 7+.
Male literacy	82.14%	Gender gap remains.
Female literacy	65.46%	Improved, but below male literacy.
Scheduled Castes	201.38 million (16.6%)	SC share of total population.
Scheduled Tribes	104.55 million (8.6%)	ST share of total population.
Work participation rate	39.8%	Census worker definition; not the same as PLFS labour-force indicators.

The 2011 population increase over 2001 was about 181.96 million persons. The decadal growth rate slowed, but the absolute addition remained very large because the population base was much larger.

Age structure and demographic transition

- The 0–6 population was about 164.5 million (roughly 13.6% of the population).
- The broad working-age group is often discussed as 15–59 or 15–64 years, depending on the analytical framework. Do not mix these denominators when quoting a percentage.
- A falling child share and rising working-age/older-age shares indicate demographic transition, but the pace differs across states.

- A demographic dividend is a potential economic advantage, not an automatic outcome. It requires education, health, skills, productive jobs, female labour-force participation and mobility.

Population growth: concepts and phases

Natural increase = crude birth rate − crude death rate. Population change also reflects net migration.

Population growth rate = (births − deaths) + (in-migration − out-migration), expressed in the appropriate population-rate framework. At the national level, international migration matters; at state/district level, internal migration can be significant.

Measure	Meaning	Do not confuse with
Decadal growth rate	Percentage change in population over a ten-year period.	Annual growth rate.
Average annual exponential growth rate	Annualised rate assuming continuous/exponential growth over the interval.	Simple arithmetic average of yearly changes.
Natural growth	Births minus deaths.	Total population growth where migration is material.
Net migration	In-migration minus out-migration.	Birth rate or death rate.

The conventional historical phases of India's population growth are: 1901–1921 (stagnant/near-stagnant, including the 1921 decline); 1921–1951 (steady growth); 1951–1981 (rapid/high growth); and 1981–2011 (high but progressively slowing growth). The year 1921 is called the 'Year of Great Divide' in Indian demographic history because it marked the transition from stagnant to sustained population growth.

Important correction to old notes The formula is not 'growth rate = birth rate − death rate = migration rate'. Migration is a separate component. Total growth combines natural increase and net migration.

3. SEX RATIO, LITERACY, DENSITY AND URBANISATION

Sex ratio

In India, sex ratio means the number of females per 1,000 males. This is the reverse of the convention used in some countries.

- Overall sex ratio: 943 in 2011, compared with 933 in 2001.

- Child sex ratio (0–6): 918 in 2011, compared with 927 in 2001. Improvement in the overall sex ratio can coexist with deterioration in the child sex ratio.
- The sex ratio is influenced by sex differentials in mortality, nutrition, healthcare, migration, social practices and sex selection. In-migration of male workers can depress the sex ratio in some urban/industrial areas.
- Do not attribute a low sex ratio to one cause alone. Distinguish sex ratio at birth, child sex ratio and overall sex ratio.

Literacy

Census literacy: a person aged seven years or more who can both read and write with understanding in any language is treated as literate. A person who can only read but cannot write is not treated as literate.

- 2011 all-India literacy: 74.04%; male: 82.14%; female: 65.46%.
- Literacy rate is calculated for the population aged seven years and above, not the entire population.
- Literacy is not identical to educational attainment, years of schooling, learning outcomes or functional literacy.

Population density

Population density = total population ÷ geographical area, generally expressed as persons per square kilometre.

- India's density rose from 325 persons/km² in 2001 to 382 in 2011.
- Physiography, climate, water availability, soils, accessibility, industrialisation, transport and historical settlement influence density.
- High density does not automatically mean high economic prosperity; low density does not automatically mean underdevelopment.

Urbanisation and Census definition

Census 2011 classified an area as urban if it was either a statutory town or a census town.

Category	Census criterion
Statutory town	A place with a municipality, corporation, cantonment board or notified town area committee/other legally constituted urban local body.
Census town	All three conditions must be satisfied together: (i) population of at least 5,000; (ii) density of at least 400 persons/km²; and (iii) at least 75% of the male main workers engaged in non-agricultural pursuits.

- The 75% criterion in the census-town definition refers to male main workers, not all residents or all workers.
- A census town may continue to be administered as a rural local body; statutory status and census classification are not identical.
- In 2011, India had about 7,933 towns (statutory and census towns together) and 6.41 lakh villages. The older 2001 count of 5,161 towns is obsolete.
- The 2011 urban population share was 31.16%, compared with 27.81% in 2001.

City / metropolis caution Do not use the 2001 handout's simplistic 'more than one lakh = city; more than one million = metropolis' as a universal legal definition. Census tables use population-size classes and urban agglomeration concepts; metropolitan planning-region terminology has separate legal meanings.

4. RELIGIOUS, LINGUISTIC AND SOCIAL COMMUNITIES OF INDIA

Religious communities: Census 2011

Religious category	Population share (2011)	Approx. population
Hindu	79.8%	96.63 crore
Muslim	14.2%	17.22 crore
Christian	2.3%	2.78 crore
Sikh	1.7%	2.08 crore
Buddhist	0.7%	0.84 crore
Jain	0.4%	0.45 crore
Other Religions & Persuasions	0.7%	0.79 crore
Religion not stated	0.2%	0.29 crore

The six major religious categories are Hindu, Muslim, Christian, Sikh, Buddhist and Jain. The Census also records 'Other Religions & Persuasions' and 'Religion not stated'. Percentages are rounded.

- Examples of faith traditions included in the 'Other Religions & Persuasions' category include several indigenous/tribal faith systems and other smaller traditions; this category is internally diverse.
- Religion data are not a direct measure of caste, language, ethnicity or tribal status. A person may belong to a notified ST community and report any religion.

Linguistic communities

The Eighth Schedule recognises 22 languages. Census mother-tongue data are collected in a much wider range of mother tongues and are grouped for publication using linguistic criteria.

Broad language family	Illustrative languages / communities
Indo-Aryan	Hindi varieties, Bengali, Marathi, Gujarati, Punjabi, Odia, Assamese, Kashmiri, Konkani, Sindhi, Urdu, Sanskrit, Dogri, Maithili, Nepali.
Dravidian	Telugu, Tamil, Kannada, Malayalam; also languages such as Gondi, Kui, Kurukh and Tulu.
Austroasiatic	Santali, Mundari, Ho, Khasi and related languages (language classification varies by branch).
Tibeto-Burman / Sino-Tibetan	Bodo, Manipuri/Meitei, many Naga languages, Mizo, Garo and numerous Himalayan and North-Eastern languages.

Language families cross state boundaries. A linguistic identity is not the same thing as a state identity, caste identity or tribe identity.

Caste and social categories: what Census data do and do not say

- Scheduled Castes (SC): communities notified by the President under Article 341 for a State/UT. The list is state/UT-specific; a community's SC status in one state does not automatically apply in another.
- Scheduled Tribes (ST): communities notified under Article 342 for a State/UT. Recognition is state/UT-specific, subject to the constitutional notification.
- Other Backward Classes (OBCs): identified under the relevant Central or State lists and applicable constitutional/legal framework. The standard published 2011 Census tables do not provide a comprehensive caste-wise population count for all OBCs.
- The 2011 Census published SC and ST counts, but not a complete caste-by-caste enumeration of the entire population.
- The Socio-Economic and Caste Census (SECC) 2011 was a separate exercise; its caste data were not released as a comprehensive, validated all-caste population table.
- In April 2025, the Union Government decided to include caste enumeration in the upcoming Census; Census 2027 notifications and schedules must be read for the actual process.

UPSC distinction Caste, tribe, religion and language are different axes of social identity. SC/ST are constitutional administrative categories; OBC is a list-based category; 'community' is a broader sociological term.

5. SCHEDULED TRIBES OF INDIA: DISTRIBUTION AND CHARACTERISTICS

India's tribal population is highly diverse. The Census 2011 recorded 104.55 million Scheduled Tribe persons, about 8.6% of India's population. Tribal communities are concentrated in central India, the North-East, the Himalayan belt and parts of the Western Ghats and southern peninsula.

Major tribal belts and representative communities

Tribal region / belt	States / areas	Illustrative communities
Central Indian belt	Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, Odisha, Maharashtra, parts of Rajasthan and Gujarat	Gond, Bhil, Santhal, Munda, Oraon/Kurukh, Ho, Baiga, Korwa, Kharia, Korku, Kondh, Saora/Savara.
North-Eastern hills	Arunachal Pradesh, Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram, Meghalaya, Tripura, Assam	Naga groups, Mizo/Lushai, Khasi, Garo, Jaintia/Pnar, Bodo, Adi, Nyishi, Apatani, Mishmi, Tripuri, Reang/Bru, Karbi, Dimasa.
Western India	Rajasthan, Gujarat, Maharashtra	Bhil, Garasia, Meena, Sahariya, Warli, Kokna, Dhodia, Rathwa, Gamit.
Himalayan belt	Ladakh, Jammu & Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Sikkim	Ladakhi/Bhoti groups, Gaddi, Gujjar (ST in specified UT/state contexts), Bhotia, Jaunsari, Tharu, Lepcha, Bhutia.
Southern peninsula / Western Ghats	Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Karnataka, Kerala, Tamil Nadu	Chenchu, Koya, Gond, Kolam, Toda, Kota, Kurumba, Irula, Paniya, Kattunayakan, Soliga, Yerava.

These are illustrative examples, not a complete list of legally notified Scheduled Tribes. Exact recognition is governed by the Constitution (Scheduled Tribes) Order as amended for the relevant State/UT.

Tribal livelihoods, settlement and cultural geography

- Forest-linked livelihoods: collection of minor forest produce, food gathering, fishing, hunting traditions (historical), shifting cultivation in some regions, and forest-based crafts.
- Agriculture: settled cultivation, terrace cultivation in hill areas, millets, paddy, pulses and mixed farming, depending on ecology.
- Pastoralism and mobility: livestock rearing and seasonal movement among selected communities and landscapes.
- Language and oral traditions: many communities speak languages belonging to Dravidian, Austroasiatic and Tibeto-Burman families, besides Indo-Aryan languages.
- Settlement pattern: hill slopes, plateaus, forest margins, river valleys and remote rural areas; however, substantial tribal populations also live in towns and cities.
- Development challenges: land alienation, insecure forest rights, displacement, low access to quality education and healthcare, malnutrition, connectivity gaps and cultural/linguistic exclusion.

Constitutional and legal safeguards

Provision / law	Core significance
Article 342	President specifies STs in relation to a State/UT; Parliament may include or exclude groups by law.
Article 244	Administration of Scheduled Areas and Tribal Areas through the Fifth and Sixth Schedules.
Fifth Schedule	Scheduled Areas and Scheduled Tribes in states other than the North-Eastern areas covered by the Sixth Schedule; Tribes Advisory Council and Governor-related provisions.
Sixth Schedule	Autonomous District Councils / Regional Councils in specified tribal areas of Assam, Meghalaya, Tripura and Mizoram.
Article 275(1)	Grants-in-aid for promoting the welfare of STs and raising the level of administration in Scheduled Areas.
Article 338A	National Commission for Scheduled Tribes (NCST).
PESA Act, 1996	Extends Part IX Panchayati Raj provisions to Scheduled Areas with adaptations;

	strengthens Gram Sabha role.
Forest Rights Act, 2006	Recognises individual and community forest rights of eligible forest-dwelling STs and other traditional forest dwellers.
SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989	Prevention of atrocities and special legal protections for SCs and STs.

Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups (PVTGs)

PVTGs are a sub-category within Scheduled Tribes identified for focused support. The national list comprises 75 PVTGs across 18 States and one Union Territory (as commonly stated in official policy material). The traditional identification indicators include pre-agricultural level of technology, low level of literacy, economic backwardness and a declining or stagnant population. These are historical identification criteria, not a label for every tribal community.

- PVTGs are not a separate constitutional category from STs; they are a development-policy classification within the ST umbrella.
- Examples from different regions include Great Andamanese, Jarawa, Onge, Sentinelese, Shompen, Baiga, Birhor, Hill Korwa, Abujh Maria, Bharia, Sahariya, Chenchu, Konda Reddi, Dongria Kondh, Lodha, Toto, and selected communities in the North-East.
- Use the official state-wise PVTG list for exact state attribution; the list and administrative treatment can be updated.

6. ANDHRA PRADESH: POPULATION PROFILE (2011 BASELINE)

Boundary note The undivided Andhra Pradesh had 84,580,777 people in Census 2011. After bifurcation, 10 districts formed Telangana; the residual Andhra Pradesh and transferred Khammam mandals require boundary adjustment. The state profile below uses the post-bifurcation AP baseline commonly reported by AP government sources: about 4.96 crore.

Indicator	Andhra Pradesh (post-bifurcation 2011 baseline)	Teaching note
Population	49,577,103 (about 4.96 crore)	2011 Census-based post-bifurcation state profile.
Area	About 1,62,968 km²	Approximate geographical area; use current official state figure if a precise administrative table is

		required.
Population density	About 304 persons/km²	State profile figure.
Sex ratio	997 females per 1,000 males	Above the 2011 national average of 943.
Decadal growth (2001–11)	About 9.21%	Lower than national 17.7%; affected by boundary and migration context.
Literacy	67.35%	Below national 74.04%.
Male literacy	74.77%	2011 state profile.
Female literacy	59.96%	Gender literacy gap remains substantial.
Rural population	About 70.5% (state profile series varies slightly by boundary treatment)	Predominantly rural.
Urban population	About 29.5%	Urbanisation concentrated in coastal and major urban centres.
SC population	About 17.1%	Census 2011-based proportion; check exact boundary-adjusted table before quoting headcount.
ST population	About 5.5%	Census 2011-based proportion; state reports may include transferred mandals.

Spatial pattern and settlement geography

- Coastal Andhra: comparatively dense settlement along the fertile coastal plains and deltaic tracts of the Godavari and Krishna; agriculture, aquaculture, ports, trade and urban corridors shape population distribution.
- Rayalaseema: drier plateau and rain-shadow conditions; settlement density and agricultural opportunities are influenced by water availability, irrigation and drought exposure.
- Northern coastal/agency belt: hill and forest tracts of Alluri Sitharama Raju, Parvathipuram Manyam and adjoining areas contain important tribal settlements.
- Urban nodes include Visakhapatnam, Vijayawada, Guntur, Tirupati, Kurnool, Nellore, Rajamahendravaram and Kakinada; the urban hierarchy has changed since 2011.

Religious and social communities

The population includes Hindu, Muslim, Christian, Jain, Sikh, Buddhist and smaller faith communities. Telugu is the dominant language; Urdu is also important, particularly in urban centres and some districts. Other linguistic communities include Odia-speaking populations in the northern border districts and migrant linguistic groups in towns.

Social composition includes numerous regionally varied agrarian, artisan, trading, pastoral, service and occupational communities, along with constitutionally notified SC, ST and OBC communities. Do not present a single caste hierarchy or numerical ranking without a clearly identified, reliable dataset.

Scheduled Tribes of Andhra Pradesh: communities and geography

The 2011 Census-based ST share is about 5.5% in the post-bifurcation Andhra Pradesh profile. The official ST list contains multiple communities and specified sub-groups; legal recognition may be geographically qualified in some entries.

Community / group	Broad geographical association / note
Koya and sub-groups	Godavari valley and agency areas; also across the Telangana–Chhattisgarh–Odisha border region.
Chenchu	Nallamala forest landscape, including parts of present-day Nandyal, Prakasam and adjoining areas; traditionally forest-dependent.
Yanadi / Yenadi	Coastal and southern Andhra districts; historically associated with forest, wetland and coastal livelihoods.
Sugali / Lambadi / Banjara	Found across several districts; historically mobile/pastoral-trading associations, now diverse livelihoods.
Yerukula	Scattered across several districts; multiple notified sub-groups.
Gond / Naikpod / Raj Gond	Northern Andhra borderland and adjoining Deccan tribal belt; check state-specific notified entries.
Savara / Saora	Northern Eastern Ghats, especially Srikakulam and adjoining hill tracts.
Jatapu	Northern coastal and Eastern Ghats districts.
Gadaba	Eastern Ghats and northern agency areas.
Kondh / Konda Dora / Konda Reddi	Eastern Ghats, agency and hill tracts;

	several distinct communities with separate legal entries.
Kolam, Thoti, Koya, Hill Reddi and others	Some groups have specified district/area conditions in the notified list.

Other entries in the Andhra Pradesh Scheduled Tribes list include Bagata, Bhil, Goudu (in Agency tracts), Kammara, Kattunayakan, Konda Kapu, Kondareddi, Kotia, Kulia, Manna Dhora, Mukha Dhora, Nayak (in Agency tracts), Pardhan, Porja, Reddi Dhora, Rona, Valmiki (in specified Scheduled Areas), Nakkala and Dhulia/Paiko/Putiya (specified districts). The notified list, not a generic ethnographic label, determines legal status.

Tribal geography and development issues in AP

- The Eastern Ghats and Godavari catchment form a major tribal landscape. Forests, hill slopes, shifting/settled cultivation, streams and access routes influence settlement.
- Agency areas and Scheduled Areas have distinct governance and land-protection concerns. The Gram Sabha's role under PESA and community/individual rights under the Forest Rights Act are important.
- Key issues include land alienation, displacement from infrastructure/mining projects, access to health and education, nutrition, road connectivity, forest produce value chains and protection of cultural-linguistic identity.
- Chenchu and other PVTG communities require context-specific interventions; avoid treating all ST households as one uniform target group.

7. TELANGANA: POPULATION PROFILE (2011 BASELINE)

Indicator	Telangana (2011 Census baseline)	Teaching note
Population	35,003,674 (about 3.50 crore)	Official state profile figure.
Area	112,077 km²	State profile.
Population density	312 persons/km²	2011 Census.
Sex ratio	988 females per 1,000 males	Above national 943.
Decadal growth (2001–11)	13.58%	Below national 17.7%.
Literacy	66.54%	Below national 74.04%.
Male literacy	75.04%	2011.
Female literacy	57.99%	2011.
Rural population	21,395,009 (61.12%)	Majority rural.
Urban population	13,608,665 (38.88%)	Hyderabad metropolitan region strongly shapes

		urban share.
SC population	5,408,800 (about 15.5%)	State Statistical Year Book / Census 2011.
ST population	3,177,940 (about 9.1%)	State Statistical Year Book / Census 2011.

Spatial pattern and settlement geography

- Telangana is predominantly a Deccan Plateau state. The Godavari and Krishna river systems, black and red soils, tank irrigation, dryland farming and plateau relief shape settlement and livelihoods.
- Hyderabad and its metropolitan region form the principal urban and economic concentration; other important urban centres include Warangal, Karimnagar, Nizamabad, Khammam, Nalgonda and Mahabubnagar.
- Northern and eastern districts, particularly the forested Godavari basin and adjoining uplands, contain significant tribal populations.
- The state's urban share (38.88%) was higher than the national 2011 average (31.16%).

Religious and social communities

The major religious communities include Hindus, Muslims and Christians, alongside smaller Jain, Sikh, Buddhist and other-faith populations. Urdu has a significant presence, particularly in Hyderabad; Telugu is the principal language. Lambadi/Banjara, Gondi, Koya and other tribal languages and dialects are part of the state's linguistic diversity.

Telangana's social composition includes diverse agrarian, pastoral, artisan, trading, service and occupational communities, alongside notified SC, ST and OBC groups. The 2011 Census does not provide a comprehensive caste-wise population count for all these communities.

Scheduled Tribes of Telangana: communities and geography

The 2011 Census-based ST population was 3,177,940, about 9.1% of the state's population. The state recognises 32 ST communities in its current official profile/administrative presentation; the statutory notified list and area-specific clauses must be consulted for legal classification.

Community / group	Broad geographical association / note
Lambadi / Banjara / Sugali	Largest ST community in the state; widespread across districts, including rural and peri-urban settings.
Koya	Godavari river valley and forested eastern districts, especially Bhadradri Kothagudem and adjoining areas.

Gond / Naikpod / Raj Gond	Northern Telangana, especially the former Adilabad region and adjoining forest belt.
Kolam	Northern Telangana, including Adilabad/Kumuram Bheem region; one of the communities associated with PVTG classification.
Chenchu	Nallamala forest landscape extending into southern Telangana and adjoining Andhra Pradesh.
Yerukula	Found across several districts; livelihoods are diverse and increasingly urban/rural mixed.
Thoti	Notified for specified districts in the historical state list; important to read the area condition carefully.
Andh, Pardhan, Konda Reddi and others	Smaller or geographically concentrated communities; use the statutory state list for exact entries.

Other named groups in the notified list include Kattunayakan, Koya sub-groups, Konda Kapu, Konda Reddi, Lambadi, Mannervarlu, Naikpod, Pardhan, Kolam, Thoti, Yerukula and other listed communities. The legal list includes 32 communities; the exact names and spellings should be taken from the latest Presidential Order/amendments.

Newer Telangana survey: do not mix denominators A Telangana 2024 socio-economic, education, employment, political and caste (SEEEPC) survey report has reported a higher ST share (10.5%) than the 2011 Census (about 9.1%). These are different exercises, dates and methodologies. For a Census-based comparison with AP and India, retain the 2011 Census number and mention the newer survey separately with its source and caveat.

Tribal geography and development issues in Telangana

- The Godavari basin, northern forested uplands and the old Adilabad–Khammam tribal belt are central to tribal geography.
- Koya settlements are strongly associated with the Godavari valley; Gond and Kolam communities are important in the northern plateau/forest region.
- Lambadi/Banjara communities are widely dispersed and should not be reduced to a single livelihood or settlement pattern.

- Important policy concerns include land and forest rights, access to public services in remote habitations, language-sensitive schooling, nutrition, displacement, livelihood diversification and protection of customary institutions.

8. ANDHRA PRADESH–TELANGANA: QUICK COMPARISON

Indicator (2011 baseline)	Andhra Pradesh*	Telangana	India
Population	4.96 crore	3.50 crore	121.09 crore
Area (approx.)	1.63 lakh km²	1.12 lakh km²	32.87 lakh km²
Density (persons/km²)	304	312	382
Sex ratio	997	988	943
Decadal growth (2001–11)	9.21%	13.58%	17.7%
Literacy	67.35%	66.54%	74.04%
Male literacy	74.77%	75.04%	82.14%
Female literacy	59.96%	57.99%	65.46%
Urban share	about 29.5%	38.88%	31.16%
SC share	about 17.1%	about 15.5%	16.6%
ST share	about 5.5%	about 9.1%	8.6%

*Andhra Pradesh figures are post-bifurcation, Census-2011-based state-profile values; some official publications show small variations because of transferred mandals, boundary treatment and rounding. Use the exact table/source specified in a question.

What the comparison tells us

- Telangana had a higher density and urban share than residual Andhra Pradesh in the 2011 baseline.
- Both states had sex ratios above the all-India average.
- Both states had literacy rates below the national average, with a persistent male–female literacy gap.
- Telangana's ST share was higher than the national average; AP's was lower than the national average in the post-bifurcation profile.
- The growth rates are not directly comparable with the undivided AP series unless boundaries and transferred areas are harmonised.

9. DISTRICT REORGANISATION: A COMMON DATA TRAP

- Census 2011 was conducted using the district/sub-district structure existing at that time. Telangana then had 10 districts; Andhra Pradesh had 13 districts after bifurcation-related mapping.

- Telangana subsequently reorganised into 31 districts in 2016 and later 33 districts. Andhra Pradesh reorganised into 26 districts in 2022.
- These new administrative districts do not have independent 2011 census enumerations in their present boundaries unless official re-tabulation/reconciliation tables are used.
- A question asking for the 2011 population of a present-day district requires aggregation of the relevant 2011 mandals/villages. Do not simply quote the old parent district total.
- For longitudinal comparison, use stable geographical units or explicitly state that boundaries changed.

10. UPSC PRELIMS: HIGH-VALUE DISTINCTIONS AND TRAPS

Statement / concept	Correct position
Census is a State subject.	Incorrect. It is Entry 69, Union List.
Article 246 itself defines census procedure.	Incorrect. Article 246 distributes legislative powers; Census Act, 1948 is the operational law.
1872 was the first synchronous census.	Incorrect. 1872 was non-synchronous; 1881 was the first synchronous census.
2011 was the 15th Census and 7th after Independence.	Correct.
Census 2027 is the 16th Census and 8th after Independence.	Correct, as announced by the Government.
Census literacy includes persons aged 5 and above.	Incorrect. The threshold is age 7+.
A census town must meet all three demographic/work criteria.	Correct: 5,000 population; 400/km²; 75% male main workers in non-agricultural pursuits.
75% criterion applies to all workers, male and female.	Incorrect. It refers to male main workers.
Overall sex ratio and child sex ratio both improved in 2001–11.	Incorrect. Overall rose to 943; child sex ratio fell to 918.
Census 2011 enumerated all castes and published full caste-wise population.	Incorrect. Comprehensive caste-wise data were not published; SC/ST tables are available.
A tribe notified in one State is automatically ST throughout India.	Incorrect. Recognition is State/UT-specific under Article 342.
PVTGs form a category outside Scheduled Tribes.	Incorrect. PVTGs are a sub-category within STs for targeted development.
A census town must have a municipality.	Incorrect. It can satisfy census criteria

	without statutory urban local-body status.
Population density is population divided by area.	Correct.
Population growth equals birth rate minus death rate only.	Incomplete. Net migration also affects population change.

12. ONE-PAGE REVISION SHEET

Topic	Remember
Census law	Census Act, 1948; Census Rules, 1990.
Constitution	Article 246; Entry 69, Union List.
History	1872 non-synchronous; 1881 first synchronous.
Latest completed census (as on 3 Nov 2026)	2011; 2027 census notified, results not yet available.
India population 2011	121.09 crore.
Growth 2001–11	17.7%.
Density	382 persons/km².
Sex ratio	943 females/1,000 males.
Child sex ratio	918 girls/1,000 boys.
Literacy	74.04%; male 82.14%; female 65.46%.
Urban share	31.16%.
SC / ST share	16.6% / 8.6%.
Religion	Hindu 79.8%; Muslim 14.2%; Christian 2.3%; Sikh 1.7%; Buddhist 0.7%; Jain 0.4%.
Census town	5,000 people + 400/km² + 75% male main workers in non-agriculture.
AP (2011 post-bifurcation baseline)	4.96 crore; density 304; sex ratio 997; literacy 67.35%; ST about 5.5%.
Telangana (2011 baseline)	3.50 crore; density 312; sex ratio 988; literacy 66.54%; ST about 9.1%.
Tribal safeguards	Articles 244, 275(1), 338A, 342; Fifth/Sixth Schedules; PESA 1996; FRA 2006.
PVTGs	75 communities nationally; sub-category within STs.

13. SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

Office of the Registrar General & Census Commissioner, India — Population Finder 2011

https://censusindia.gov.in/census.website/en/data/population-finder — Official district/sub-district/town/village PCA tables; SC/ST, work and age indicators.

Census of India — official portal

https://censusindia.gov.in/census.website/en — Census 2027 announcements, notifications, schedules and official data.

PIB — Census 2027 to be conducted in two phases along with enumeration of castes (4 June 2025)

https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2133845&lang=2&reg=48 — Government announcement on two phases, reference date and caste enumeration.

PIB — Census 2027 press conference (30 March 2026)

https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2246847&lang=1&reg=20 — Digital census, self-enumeration, 2011 as last census and Census 2027 details.

PIB — Population by Religious Communities, Census 2011 (25 August 2015)

https://www.pib.gov.in/newsite/printrelease.aspx?lang=2&reg=3&relid=126326 — All-India religious community proportions and counts.

PIB — Census 2011 primary data release

https://www.pib.gov.in/newsite/PrintRelease.aspx?lang=2&reg=3&relid=95372 — Population, rural/urban, density, sex ratio, SC/ST and growth.

Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation — Food and Nutrition Security Analysis, India

https://www.mospi.gov.in/sites/default/files/publication_reports/document%281%29.pdf — Demographic profile and SC/ST proportions.

Government of Telangana — State Profile

https://www.telangana.gov.in/about/state-profile/ — Telangana 2011 population, density, sex ratio, urban/rural, SC/ST and literacy profile.

Directorate of Economics and Statistics, Telangana — Statistical Year Book 2017

https://www.des.telangana.gov.in/publications/Statistical_Year_Book_2017.pdf — Detailed Telangana 2011 demographic and SC/ST tables.

Government of Andhra Pradesh — Educational Statistics / AP at a Glance

https://cse.ap.gov.in/MISdownload/MIS_REPORT_NOTIFICATION/Educational%20Statistics%202019-20.pdf — AP post-bifurcation 2011 population profile, literacy, density, sex ratio and urban/rural indicators.

Census of India — A-11 Andhra Pradesh, individual ST PCA (2011)

https://censusindia.mha.gov.in/nada/index.php/catalog/42967 — Official list/table for individual Scheduled Tribe populations.

Census of India — A-11 Appendix, district-wise ST population, Andhra Pradesh (2011)

https://censusindia.gov.in/nada/index.php/catalog/43027 — Official district-wise ST population appendix and tribe names.

Ministry of Tribal Affairs — Annual Report 2011–12, Annexure: State-wise list of Scheduled Tribes

https://tribal.gov.in/downloads/statistics/AnnualReport/AR2011-12.pdf — State-wise ST list; verify latest amendments before legal use.

Telangana 2024 SEEEPC expert-group report

https://des.telangana.gov.in/publications/SEEEPC/SEEEPC-IEWG%20Volume-1%2017-04-26.pdf — Newer state survey context; not interchangeable with Census 2011.